



HP unveils new range

HP recently updated its Laptop and Ultrabook range with the Envy x2 Hybrid and Envy m6 laptops which will be a part of HP's Windows 8 portfolio



App store for Raspberry Pi

The Raspberry Pi Foundation has released an app store which allows users to share their home-made software for the Pi. <http://dgit.in/12xoNM8>

Feature

as water resistance, where the tablet is kept in a rain chamber supplying rain at a rate of no less than 4 inches per hour. The government asked IIT to withdraw its 'military-level' test criteria and stressed focussing on 'consumer friendly' features. Later, IIT-Rajasthan was pulled out of the project.

Aakash 2.0 replaces the Aakash

On November 11, 2012, President Pranab Mukherjee unveiled the Aakash 2 at an event in New Delhi. DataWind designed, developed and manufactured the Aakash 2.0 whereas the device's platform was developed by IIT Bombay that includes 3D-modelling, C++ programming, remote and collaborative training applications, robotic control and live assessment tools. IIT Bombay partnered with the Center for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC), to assist with the hardware testing and logistics.

The Aakash 2.0 specifications include a 7-inch multi-touch 4-point capacitive display with 800 x 480 pixel resolution, Android 4.0 Ice Cream Sandwich OS, 512 MB of RAM, Cortex A8 1 GHz processor, 4GB built-in storage, microSD card slot that supports storage up to 32 GB, micro USB, Wi-Fi b/g/n and a 3,000 mAh battery.

The Aakash 2.0 was showcased at the United Nations on November 28, 2012. UN Secretary-General Ban Ki-Moon showered praise on India's efforts to bring modern technology to everyone's door steps. He said, "We know technology is not an end in itself. The key is to empower people to make the most of their own potential. Information and communications technologies are engines of economic growth and development and can help transform people's lives. They are great enablers – helping people communicate across distances, facilitating trade and commerce and providing better access to health care and education."

Aakash 2: A Made in China device?

Days before it was unveiled at the UN, the Aakash 2 ran into another controversy with media reports claiming the device was a Made in China device. Reports said DataWind had procured the tablets off-the-shelf from manufacturers in China for \$42

(Rs. 2,263 then), exactly the price at which they sold these to the Indian government. DataWind, however, denied the allegations. DataWind also put an explanation on its website detailing where the Aakash 2 tablets are made and assembled.

DataWind's CEO Suneet Singh Tuli, however, believes 'Made in India' tag is important. When we contacted Mr. Tuli and he said, "We believe that Made in India is important and specific Indian level value-adds to should be a criteria for future tenders. This would create a defined criteria for the 'Made in India' tag, so that there is no controversy." (Full interview: <http://dgit.in/datatuli>)

Tuli is also hopeful India can develop a 'Made in India' tablet on a large scale. "a focussed effort should be made to develop indigenous manu-



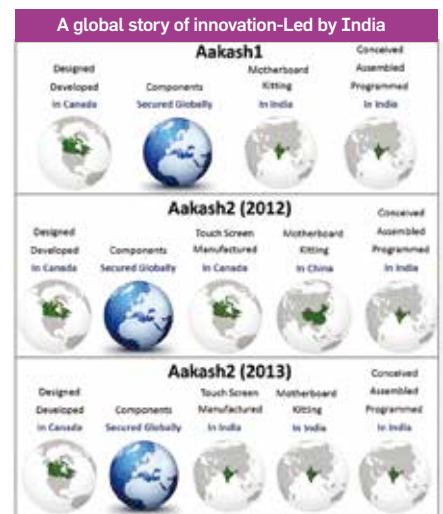
Ban Ki-moon unveiling the Aakash 2

facturing – but with the maturity to understand that components will come from around the world," he added.

Why Aakash can make a difference?

The world's biggest democracy has shown great promise in the past, but it's been held back by education and infrastructure problems. The success of Aakash could completely change this, in fact it could lay foundation for a modern and improved education infrastructure in India – which we've all been dreaming and striving for so long.

That being said, we have to be honest to ourselves. The entire education system cannot rely on tablet hardware for the overhaul it is striving and to deliver the quality knowledge to the students.



Where Aakash 2 is made, assembled and manufactured

The success of the Aakash tablet is just part of a goal, not the ultimate goal.

But that is easier said than done. The government has to create an environment where the tablet and the related benefits are optimally harnessed. It may seem difficult at this stage, but it's definitely not impossible. Moreover, the government has to work on the economics and ensure the subsidy (whopping 50 percent on each unit) does not hurt it in long-term.

Unlike other ongoing state-run projects, the government should try to make it commercially successful, which would set an example for other schemes. A lot of hard work has to be done on awareness. People should know about it. We don't expect the government to run Pulse Polio, free-cycle, Mid-Day meal or Aadhar-like campaign across the country, but there has to be some work and exposure at the ground level.

We feel the Ministry of Human Resource Development's described vision precisely defines why ultra-low-cost tablet or Aakash-like technology is important for India and its large young population. It says on its site: "... [The] young population should be considered as an invaluable asset which if equipped with knowledge and skills, can contribute effectively to the development of the national as well as the global economy. The vision is to realize India's human resource potential to its fullest in the education sector, with equity and inclusion."